Phishing Awareness & Safe Browsing

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Phishing Awareness & Safe Browsing

Why vigilance matters in the digital age

- **Elevated risk landscape**: Cybercriminals exploit human trust, making awareness the first line of defense.
- **Safe browsing fundamentals**: Adopting habit loops—verify, pause, proceed—reduces exposure to malicious sites.

What is Phishing?

Deceptive tactics that harvest confidential data

- **Definition**: A social-engineering ploy that masquerades as a trusted entity to steal credentials or personal information.
- **Simple example**: A counterfeit login page mimicking a bank, prompting users to enter their username and password.

Phishing Attack

Fake Email Example

Red flags that signal a malicious message

Weird sender address

Domain misspelling or unrelated corporate suffix that doesn't match the purported organization.

Urgent, threatening message

Language that pressures immediate action, often invoking account suspension or legal consequences.

Embedded fake link

Hyperlink text appears legitimate but URL redirects to an unknown or malicious domain.

Real vs. Fake Comparison

Spotting authentic communication versus phishing attempts

- **Legitimate email traits**: Professional branding, correct grammar, personalized greeting, and a verifiable corporate domain.
- **Phishing email traits**: Generic salutations, spelling errors, mismatched URLs, and unsolicited requests for sensitive data.

Photo by Andrew Dunstan on Unsplash

How to Stay Safe

Practical steps for everyday digital hygiene

Don’t click suspicious links

Hover to preview URLs; avoid clicking when the address looks obfuscated or unrelated.

Verify sender identity

Cross-check the email address with known contacts or official directories before responding.

Check for HTTPS and padlock

Ensure the website uses TLS encryption (https://) and displays the padlock icon before entering credentials.

Key Takeaways

Embedding vigilance into daily workflows

- **Always verify source before interacting**: Treat every unsolicited request as potentially fraudulent until proven trustworthy.
- **Maintain a cautious mindset online**: Adopt a default-deny posture; assume threats exist and act accordingly.